Useful vocabulary for describing data

You don't need rare words to show range. You need precise, natural words, used with the right grammar. Learn these with their patterns, not as a list of synonyms.

Choose the word the graph supports. "Rise" can go with slightly, steadily or sharply: the data decides which one is accurate. Neutral words such as rose, fell and remained stable are always safe.

WORD	PATTERN	EXAMPLE	COMMON MISUSE
INCREASES			
climb	X climbed (steadily) from A to B	*Sales climbed steadily from 2 million to 5 million.*	Using it for a sudden jump. Climb suggests a steady rise.
surge	X surged · a surge in X	*Ticket sales surged in December.*	"Surged steadily": a surge is sudden. The graph shows how long it lasted.
soar	X soared (from A) to B	*Prices soared from €2 to €9.*	Using it for a small rise. Soar means a large, rapid rise.
edge up	X edged up (from A) to B	*Unemployment edged up from 4.1% to 4.3%.*	"Edged up dramatically": edge up means a very small rise.
DECREASES			
decline	X declined (by A) to B · a decline in X	*Car use declined from 58% to 37%.*	"Declined of 21 points": after the verb, use by.
dip	X dipped to B (before recovering)	*Sales dipped to 3.8 million in 2020 before recovering.*	Using it for a large or long fall. A dip is small and short.
plummet	X plummeted (from A) to B	*Passenger numbers plummeted from 72,000 to 40,000 in one month.*	"Plummeted gradually": plummet means fast and large.
STABILITY AND MOVEMENT			
remain stable	X remained stable at A	*Prices remained stable at €2.30 between 2016 and 2018.*	"Remained stably": remain takes an adjective.
level off	X levelled off at A	*After 2018, sales levelled off at around 60,000.*	Using it for a line that was flat all along. Level off follows a rise or fall.
hover around	X hovered around A	*The rate hovered around 40% for five years.*	Using it for large movements. It means close to one level.
fluctuate	X fluctuated (between A and B)	*Visitor numbers fluctuated between 7,000 and 9,000.*	Using it for a line with one dip. Fluctuating means repeated ups and downs.

WORD	PATTERN	EXAMPLE	COMMON MISUSE
COMPARING LINES			
overtake	X overtook Y (between year and year)	*Online sales overtook in-store sales between 2016 and 2018.*	Using it when X was higher all along. Overtaking needs a crossover.
lag behind	X lagged behind Y	*Brazil's figure lagged behind the UK's in every year.*	"Brazil's figure lagged behind the UK": a figure compared with a country. Compare like with like.
SIZE OF A CHANGE			
slight	a slight rise in X	*There was a slight rise in prices in 2016.*	"A slightly rise": before a noun, use the adjective.
substantial	a substantial increase in X	*There was a substantial increase in cycling.*	Using it for a small change. Substantial means large.

AVOID THESE AS SYNONYMS FOR "INCREASE"

expedite (to make a process happen faster), **augment** (to add to something), **proliferate** (to multiply in number or variety), **escalate** (usually for conflict or problems getting worse). They have different meanings and need different sentence structures.

CHECK BEFORE YOU WRITE

1. Which way did the line move? 2. How big was the change? Calculate it. 3. How fast? 4. Does your word carry a feeling the data doesn't? If so, choose a neutral one.